



Rise. Register. Grow.

In business, leaders often talk about a "VUCA" world — one defined by Volatility, Uncertainty, Complexity, and Ambiguity (Bennett & Lemoine, 2014). Prices shift overnight, regulations change, and the road to formalising a small food business can feel impossible to predict. That is exactly the world our traders are operating in. So in this VUCA world, we are here to help you VUKA ;-)

Journey 1: Is Your Business Ready to Grow?

This is **Journey 01** of the VUKA curriculum: every journey a food trader needs, from checking whether you're ready to grow, right through to scaling into a bigger business, in one consistent, scenario-driven format.

Each lesson takes 3–7 minutes: a real scenario, a quick explanation, one practical tip, a quick challenge, and a badge.

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Journey 1: Is Your Business Ready to Grow?

"You're thinking about a second stall, more stock, or your first helper. But how do you actually know if you're ready, or just hopeful?"

Growing too soon, before your foundation is strong, can put a trader into debt or under strain. This journey helps you check your own signs before you spend a single extra rand.



The Five Signs You're Actually Ready

"Every trader dreams of expanding. But how many actually check if the timing is right first?"

Business advisors point to a consistent set of signs that show a business has a strong enough base to grow safely. Your income is steady or growing over several months, not just on the odd good week. A high number of your customers come back again and again, which shows real trust. You regularly sell out or have to turn customers away, meaning there's more demand than you can currently meet. Your notebook records are in order, so you can actually see your profit trend over time. And you have some savings or a buffer, so you're not relying on every rand of today's profit to restock tomorrow (Startup Mag, 2025; Lula, 2025).



QUICK TIP Don't wait until all five signs are perfect. Even having three or four in place is often enough to take one small, careful step.



QUICK CHALLENGE Go through the five signs above as a checklist against your own notebook records, and note which ones you already have.

Complete this and earn:  **"Growth Signal" badge**



What "Growing" Actually Looks Like

"Growing doesn't always mean a whole new shop. What's the smallest next step that would actually take you further?"

Growth doesn't have to mean a second stall straight away. For a food trader, it can look like adding a new product line, extending your trading hours for flexibility, taking on a helper, or, eventually, opening a second spot. The smaller the step, the smaller the risk if it doesn't work out exactly as planned.



QUICK TIP Match your growth step to your strongest sign. If you keep selling out, extending your hours or adding stock is a safer first move than renting a second stall.



QUICK CHALLENGE Pick one growth option from this lesson, and write down what would need to be true first before you commit to it.

Complete this and earn:  **"Ready to Rise" badge**

Sources for Fact-Checking: Legislation & Regulation

Every legal fact in Journeys 3, 4, and 10 is drawn from current South African legislation and regulator guidance:

- Regulations Governing General Hygiene Requirements for Food Premises (R638 of 2018), under the Foodstuffs, Cosmetics and Disinfectants Act 54 of 1972 — enforced by municipal Environmental Health Departments.
- Regulations Relating to the Labelling and Advertising of Foodstuffs (R146), under the Foodstuffs, Cosmetics and Disinfectants Act 54 of 1972 — Department of Health.
- Businesses Act 71 of 1991 — gov.za.
- Companies Act 71 of 2008 and Companies and Intellectual Property Commission (CIPC) — company registration, business structure conversion, and trade mark registration — cipc.co.za.
- National Regulator for Compulsory Specifications (NRCS), Food and Associated Industries division — canned, smoked, and vacuum-packed products — nrcs.org.za.



- South African Revenue Service (SARS), Small Businesses – Taxpayers, Tax Compliance Status system, and Budget 2026 Frequently Asked Questions (VAT and Turnover Tax threshold changes effective 1 April 2026) — sars.gov.za.
- Unemployment Insurance Act 63 of 2001 and Unemployment Insurance Contributions Act 4 of 2002 — Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- Compensation for Occupational Injuries and Diseases Act 130 of 1993 (COIDA) — Compensation Fund, Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- Basic Conditions of Employment Act 75 of 1997 — Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- National Environmental Management: Waste Act 59 of 2008 and Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) Regulations (Government Notice R.1184, 2020) — Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment — dffe.gov.za.
- Broad-Based Black Economic Empowerment Act 53 of 2003, and the Codes of Good Practice on B-BBEE (Exempted Micro-Enterprise thresholds) — dtic.gov.za.
- Protection of Personal Information Act 4 of 2013 (POPIA) — Information Regulator South Africa — info regulator.org.za.
- Consumer Protection Act 68 of 2008 — online and distance sales provisions — gov.za.
- African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) — South African implementation guidance — dtic.gov.za.

Note: municipal fees, thresholds, and application processes vary by area and are periodically revised by government and regulators. Verify current requirements directly with the relevant municipality or regulator before publishing final figures in the app.

Sources & Further Reading: Business Practice, Marketing & Financial Literacy

Branding and digital marketing facts in Journeys 6 and 7 draw on the following:

- Cloudfusion (2025). 7 Essential Reasons Why Branding Is Important for Business. Cloudfusion.co.za.
- Dandu, R. (2015). What Is Branding and Why Is It Important for Your Business? Brandingmag.
- Mercer, S. (2026). What to Post When You Have Nothing to Post: 10 Content Ideas for Summerville Businesses. What's Up Summerville.
- Why food photography is important for your food business. candyfoxstudio.com.
- Yolisa Motha (2021). A Guide to Branding a Small Business. iKhokha.

Statistics on South African small business communication, time management, professionalism, networking, record-keeping, and banking (Journeys 1, 2, 8, and 9) are drawn from national small business research. Verify current figures against original sources before publishing final numbers in the app.

Growth-readiness, lending-risk, funding, and stock-management facts in Journeys 1, 2, 5, and 9 draw on the following:

- National Debt Advisors (2021). Stay away from unregistered money-lenders. nationaldebtadvisors.co.za.
- Startup Mag (2025). Scaling Signals: Ten Signs Your Small Business Is Ready to Grow. startupmag.co.za; Lula (2025). 5 Signs Your Business is Ready for Growth Capital. lula.co.za.
- RegInsights (2024). Small Business Funding. regenesys.net/reginsights.
- Graduates24 (n.d.). NYDA Grant Programme Small Business Funding in South Africa. graduates24.com.
- Okhantu (2025). SEDFA Funding 2026: Requirements, Amounts & How to Apply. okhantu.co.za.
- Ready Accounting (2026). Inventory management tips for cost savings and efficiency. readyaccounting.co.za.
- Xtraspace (2024). Small Business Inventory Management in SA: 10 Top Tips. xtraspace.co.za.

Sources & Further Reading: The VUCA Concept

The mission statement on the cover page draws on the following:

- Bennett, N., & Lemoine, G. J. (2014). What VUCA Really Means for You. *Harvard Business Review*, 92(1/2), 27.

